Covers for the Accidental Guides

Brian’s question. Do the engravings fit the modern typesetting, colour and other elements of the guides? Do they add to or take away from the unity of the design? Is there a better option, more Swiss/Bauhaus, with a modern take?

Do they fit?

Not on the covers. They’re good pictures in the wrong system. They come from another century, they’re drawn in hatched grey against flat colour, and their subjects are metaphors you have to explain. Each one floats on its own, not on the grid.

Do they help unity?

They help one thing: today every cover is the same white card at thumbnail size, and the engravings at least make them different. But they do it by adding a second visual language, so the series looks less like one thing, not more.

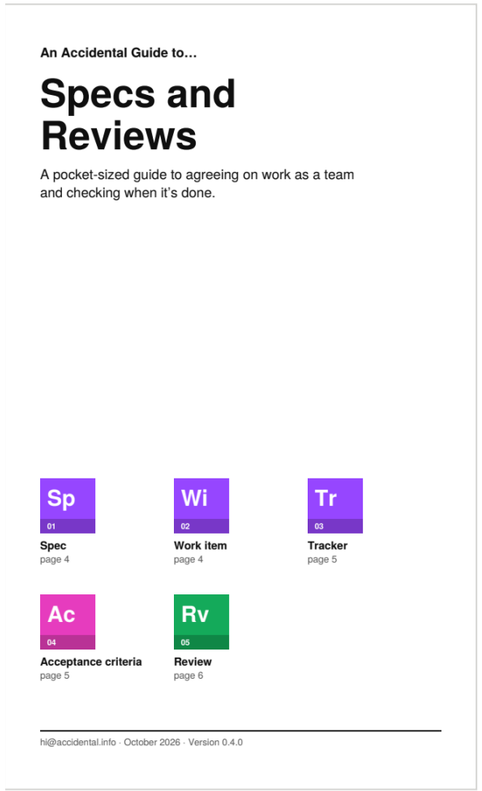
What instead?

B, the part grid. Each cover puts its own coloured tiles on a fixed six-column grid, one column per family. The art comes from the guide’s content, costs nothing per guide, and shows readers the colour rule on every cover. Keep the engravings as a reference, on the about page.

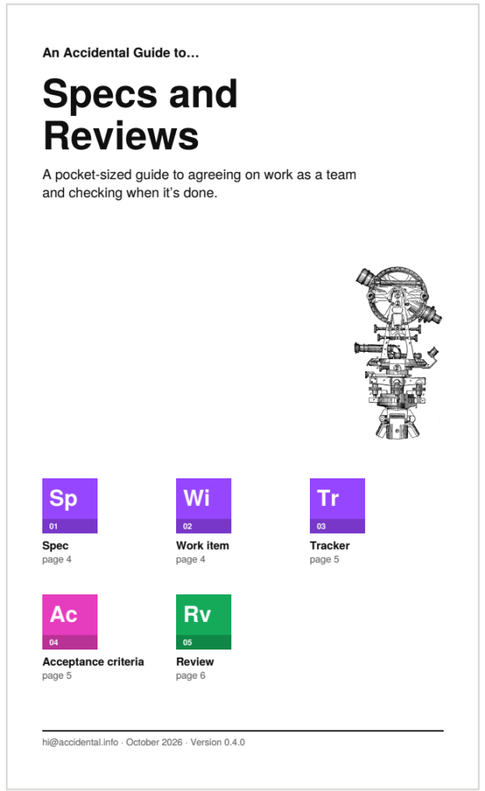
01 · Critique

The engravings are charming, and they’re not part of this system

The guides are already a Swiss system: Helvetica, a strict margin, flat saturated tiles, one meaning per colour, grey blocks, no ornament. Here’s a real cover today and the same cover with its engraving, placed where the sample covers put it.



Now. Redrawn by the study script with the guide’s own fonts, sizes and data.



With the engraving (project management: a theodolite, EB 1911), at the size and place the sample covers use.

Where they add

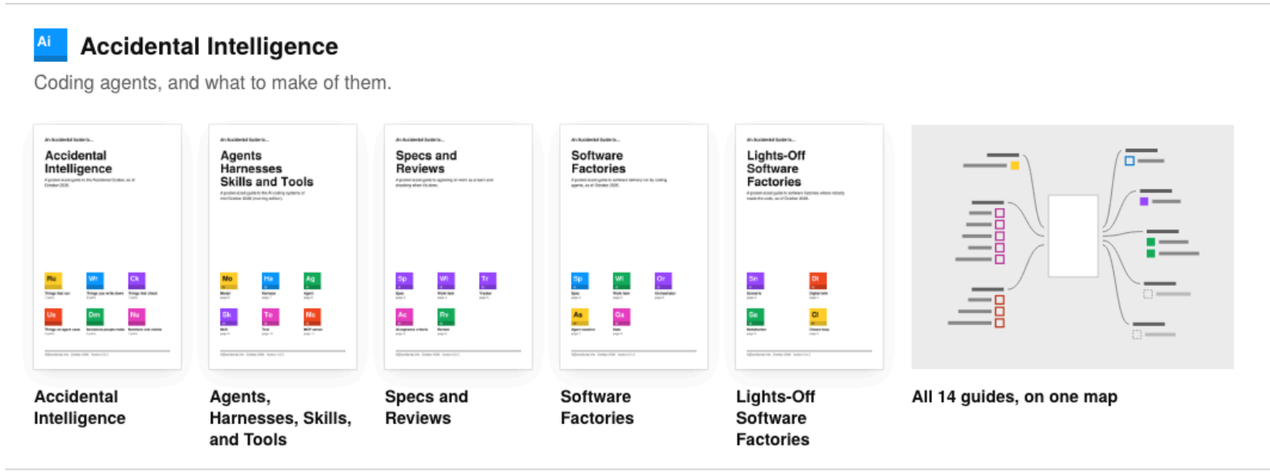
- **Identity at a glance.** On the site the covers sit at about 120 px wide, and today they’re identical (below). An engraving is the first thing that makes one cover different from the next.
- **The joke.** Babbage’s engine for the AI catalog, the chess Turk (a machine with a person hidden inside) for Games, a magnifying glass for checking claims. That’s the series’ tone: a little dry, a little self-mocking.
- **Craft.** Steel and wood engraving is beautiful line work, and it’s free to use.

Where they clash

- **Era.** 1783 to 1911 against a 1957 typeface and 2020s Figma colours. O’Reilly made engravings work with a period serif. Next to Helvetica they read as an illustration somebody chose, not part of the page.
- **Line density.** Engravings get their tone from hatching, about 30 to 60% grey. The tiles are flat and saturated. On one page they fight, and at thumbnail size the dense plates (Babbage, the loom, the Turk) go to grey smudges.
- **Colour.** In this series colour means one thing, the part’s family. The engravings are the only element with no colour and no meaning, and tinting them would give colour a second job.
- **The grid.** Each image is a different shape, scale and viewpoint, floating right-aligned in the space between subtitle and tiles. A grid can hold images (Marber, Unigrid), but only if every image gets the same field.
- **Meaning.** They show groups, not guides, so five harness guides share one typewriter. The metaphors need a caption: a theodolite for project management, a brace and bit for extending an agent.
- **Supply.** Each new group means another archive search, a licence check, a cleanup pass and judgement calls. Two picks already carry a caution (the Turk’s costume, a face on the vaporiser).

Today, on the site

The thumbnail problem the engravings were really solving



accidental.info today. Five covers, one white card. Any new direction has to fix this, at this size.

Precedents

Both ways, and what each one actually teaches.

Precedent	What it did	What it says about the engravings
O’Reilly animals	Edie Freedman’s covers: a 19th-century animal engraving, large and centred, over a colour band, in a Garamond.	**For, with conditions.** It works because the subject class (animals), size and position never change and the type comes from the same period. Ours change subject, sit small, and use Helvetica. Engravings on a tech book also now read as O’Reilly, or as a parody of it.
Penguin, Marber grid (1961)	A fixed typographic top band; below it, a full field for a commissioned image that changes with each book.	**Partly for.** A grid can hold very different images, but each image gets the whole field, and the images were made then, in the same modern spirit as the type.
Unigrid, Vignelli (1977)	One black band and one modular grid for hundreds of National Park Service brochures.	**The system is the identity.** Pictures change; the band and the grid never do. The starting point for C, and the best case for D.
Müller-Brockmann	Concert posters and *Grid Systems*: the type and the grid are the image.	**Against.** Abstraction drawn from the content, not added to it. The starting point for B and C.
Aicher, Munich ’72	Pictograms on a square grid with 90° and 45° strokes, one weight, one colour, every sport drawn by the same rules.	**Against the engravings, for A.** The simplest drawing that still says what it is, made from one rule book so it scales.
Isotype, Neurath and Arntz	Flat signs, no perspective, quantity shown by repeating the sign.	**Against, for A and B.** Pictures that count. B is Isotype applied to a guide’s parts.
Bauhaus print	Bayer, Moholy-Nagy, Schmidt: asymmetric layouts, bars, primary geometry.	**Against.** Source of the four collection marks (square, triangle, circle, diamond) and of B’s diagonal compositions.
GOV.UK	No decoration at all; type, spacing and plain words carry everything.	**Against.** Proof that plain is enough for an anxious reader, as long as the hierarchy is right.
Stripe Press	A cohesive, deliberately bookish list where each cover is designed one by one.	**Neutral.** Shows what that charm costs: every cover is a commission. That doesn’t scale to dozens of five-minute guides.

02 · Directions

Four systems, each built to scale to dozens of guides

Every mockup uses the guides' real page (324 × 540 pt), fonts, tile drawing, titles, subtitles, parts, families and page numbers, rendered with ReportLab at 2×. Only the art and the layout change. A, B and D share one new line at the top: the collection's mark, its name and the guide's number.

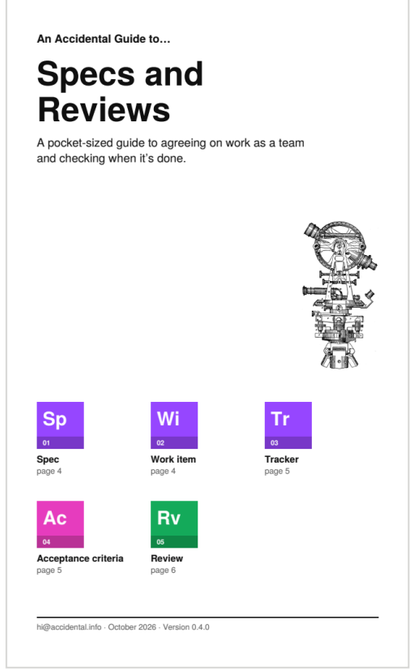
Shared: collection marks

Colour already means a part's family, so collections shouldn't get colours of their own. Today the site does give them colours (Accidental Intelligence blue, Around the house yellow, At the table red, Games green), which makes yellow mean both "things that run" and "the house". Instead, each collection gets a black Bauhaus primary: ■ **Accidental Intelligence,** ▲ **Around the house,** ● **At the table,** ◆ **Games**. A fifth collection could take a half-disc or a bar. This is worth doing whichever direction is picked.

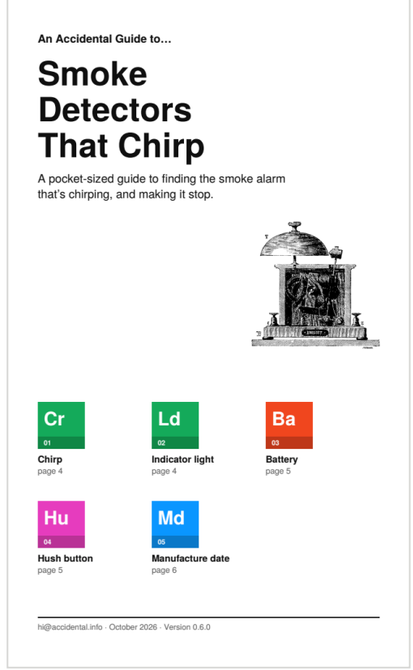
E

The engravings, as proposed

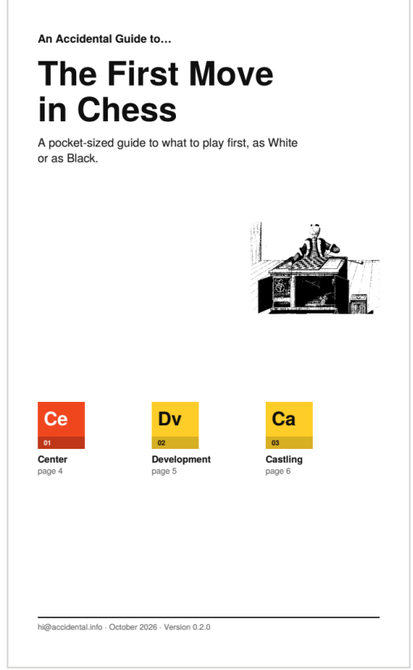
The sample covers' treatment, here applied to these eight guides: the current cover plus an engraving, right-aligned, 27% of the page width (32% for collection pictures), top at 180 pt.



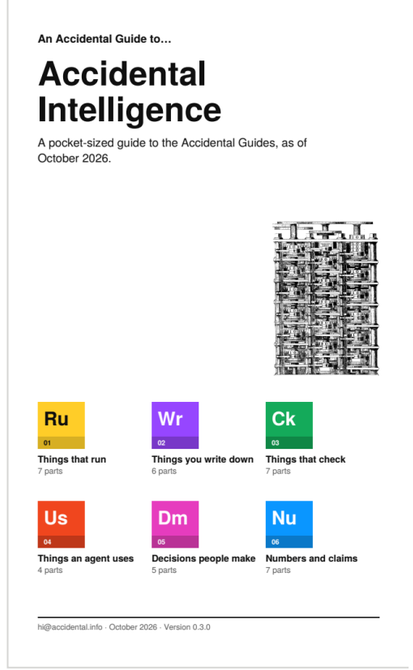
Specs and Reviews · theodolite



Smoke Detectors · Breguet bell



The First Move in Chess · the Turk



Accidental Intelligence · Babbage's engine

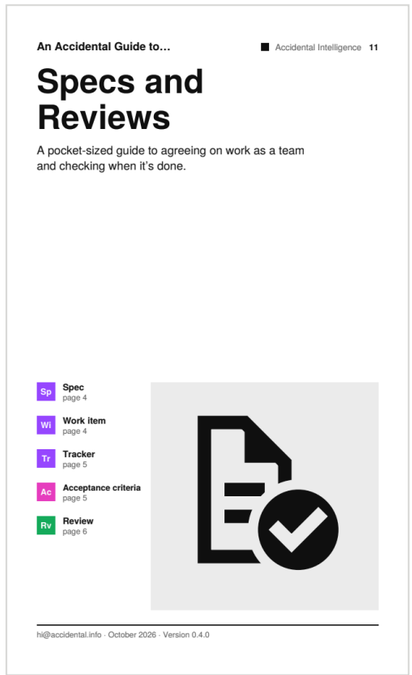
A

Signs

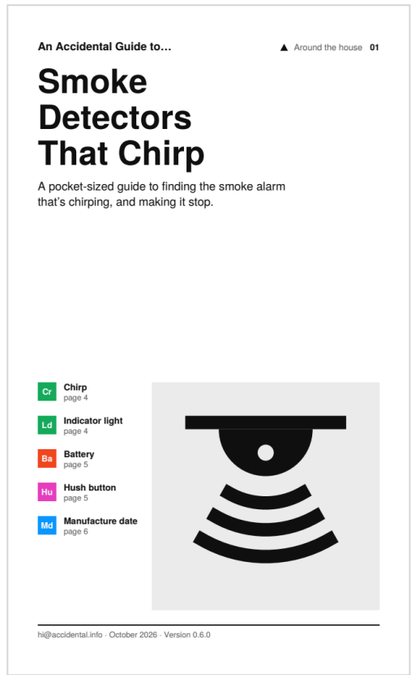
One pictogram per guide, drawn to Aicher’s and Arntz’s rules, in ink on the series’ grey block. The parts become a compact contents list beside it.

Rules

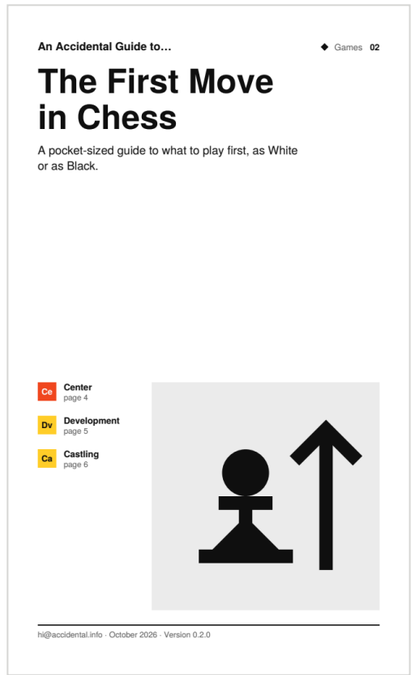
1. A 12 × 12 unit grid inside a 16-unit field. One stroke weight, 1 unit, square caps.
2. Only 0°, 45° and 90° lines; circles and arcs centred on grid points.
3. One ink, no colour: colour stays with the part tiles. Overlaps are cut apart with a 0.75-unit white gap.
4. On the cover: a grey square two columns wide, bottom-right; contents in the left column.



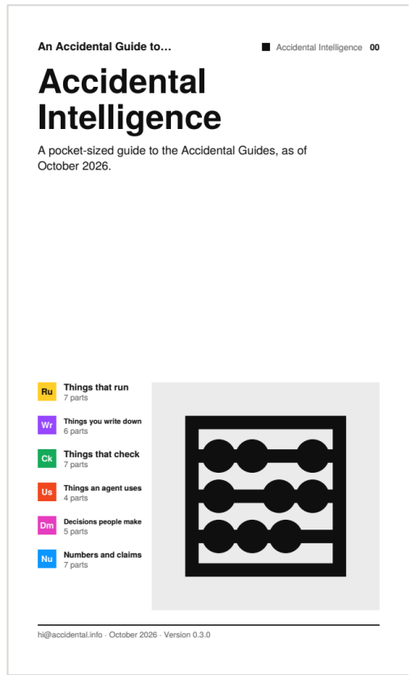
A page with a folded corner and a review mark



The ceiling, the alarm, its light, and the chirp

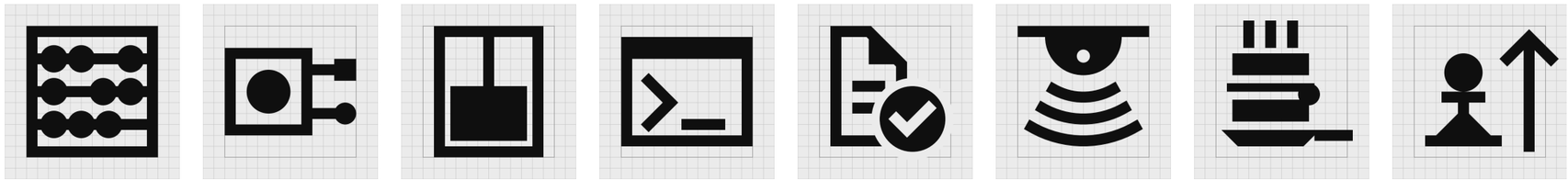


A pawn and its first move



A counting frame: the oldest calculating machine for the series about the newest

The signs on their grid





Cost per new guide

One sign, 20 to 60 minutes of careful drawing in code

Good

The direct answer to “the simpler the illustration, the easier it is to use”: the same sign works on the cover, as a favicon, on a share card, beside a link. It keeps the joke (steam off the pan, the chirp), and the grey squares give the shelf a strong, even beat.

Hard

Concrete subjects draw themselves: an alarm, a pan, a pawn. The AI guides, two-thirds of the series, are abstract. The five harness guides would all be windows and terminals, and words like plugin, skill and software factory drift toward generic icon-library glyphs (a plug, a puzzle piece, a gear). Getting past that takes real drawing time for every guide.

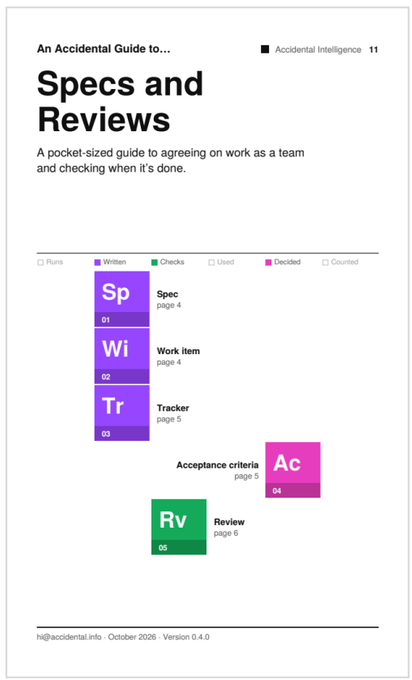
B

The part grid

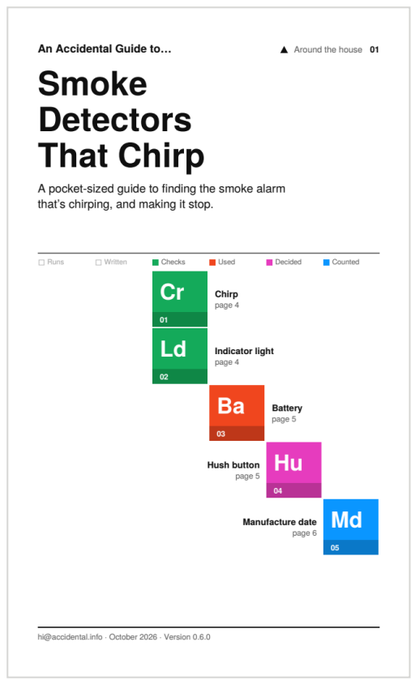
The cover's art is the guide itself. Six columns, one per family, always in the same order; one row per entry. Each part's tile sits where its family meets its entry number, so every guide makes its own pattern on the same grid.

Rules

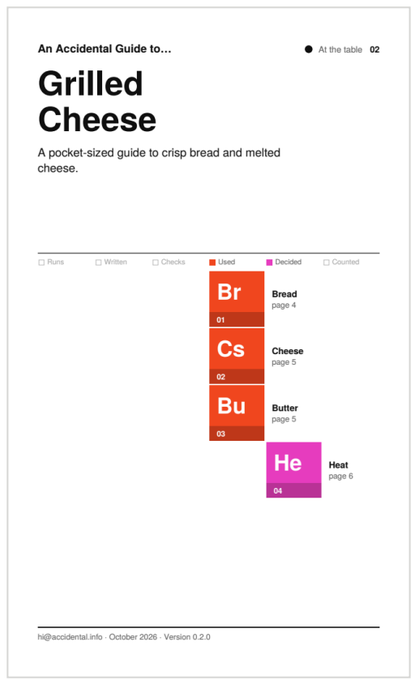
1. Six columns across the measure (46 pt each), six rows: the series already caps a guide at six parts.
2. Column heads are one word per family: Runs, Written, Checks, Used, Decided, Counted. Families the guide covers get a filled swatch, the rest an empty outline (the strip `design-direction.md` already proposes).
3. The tiles are today's two-tone tiles, number in the band. Each name and page sits beside its tile, on the right where it fits, otherwise on the left.
4. No empty cells are drawn. The structure is the column heads and the alignment, not a ruled grid.



Mostly written-down things, one decision and one check: the cover says so



Two checks, then a staircase

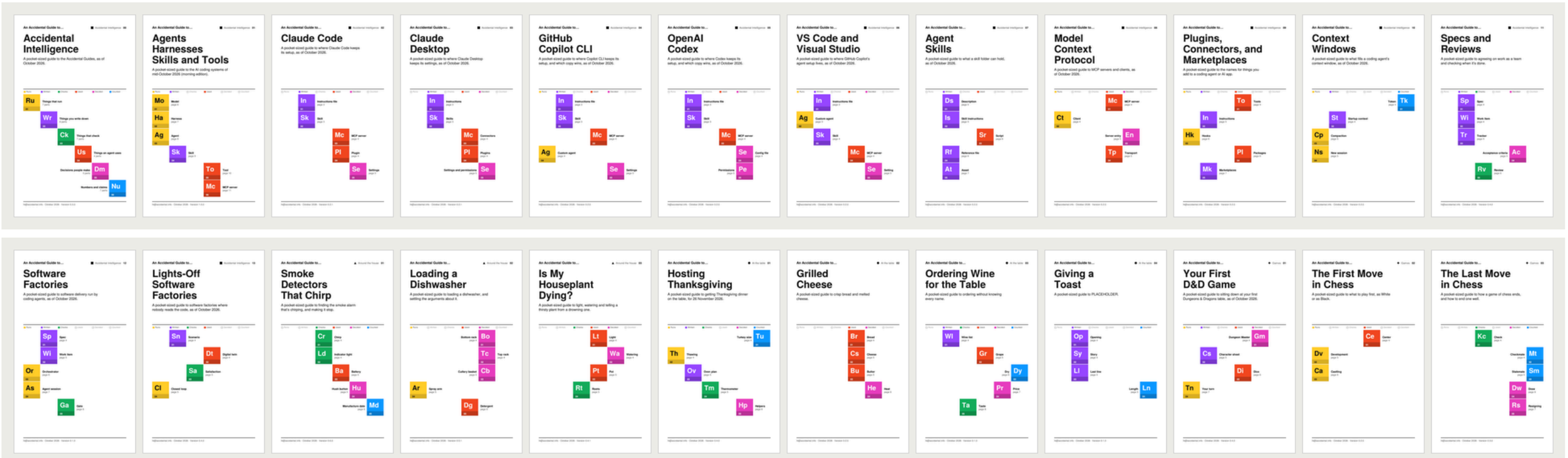


Three things you use and one decision (the heat)



The catalog's parts are the six families: a diagonal, the key to every other cover

Every guide in the repository today, with no extra work



The pattern alone, as a mark for site lists and thumb tabs. Claude Code and Claude Desktop come out identical because they cover the same five parts. That’s true, but it means titles have to tell sibling guides apart.

Cost per new guide

None. The builder draws the cover from the parts it already has.

Good

Unity comes from the rules, not from anyone’s taste: every cover is the same system, by definition. Colour gets more meaning, not a second job; a reader who has seen two covers can read the third. It’s Isotype and Bauhaus without nostalgia, and it looks like nothing else on a shelf. At thumbnail size each cover is a distinct pattern.

Hard

It never pictures the subject: the smoke alarm is in the title, not the art. Sibling guides look alike. It’s the most cerebral of the four, so the warmth has to come from the subtitles and the writing. It also depends on every part having a settled family; four older builders don’t have `PART_FAMILY` yet.

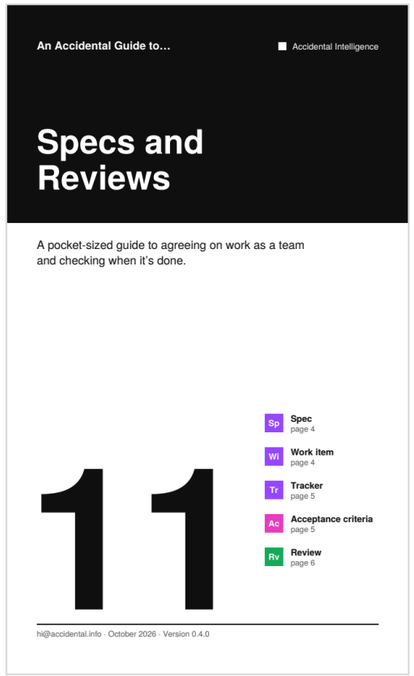
C

Band and number

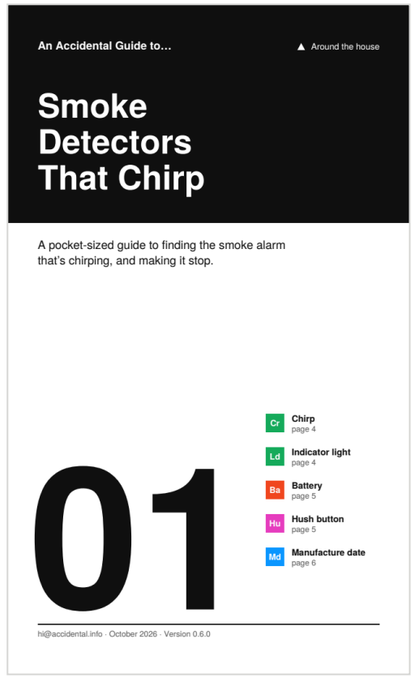
Pure typography, Unigrid style. A fixed black band holds the kicker, the collection and the title, set on the band’s foot. A large series number fills the lower field, with the contents beside it.

Rules

1. Band 176 pt, full bleed; the title’s last line always sits 14 pt above its foot.
2. The number is the guide’s place in its collection, at 160 pt. The catalog is 00.
3. Numbers are permanent once given, like Penguin’s, and never reused.



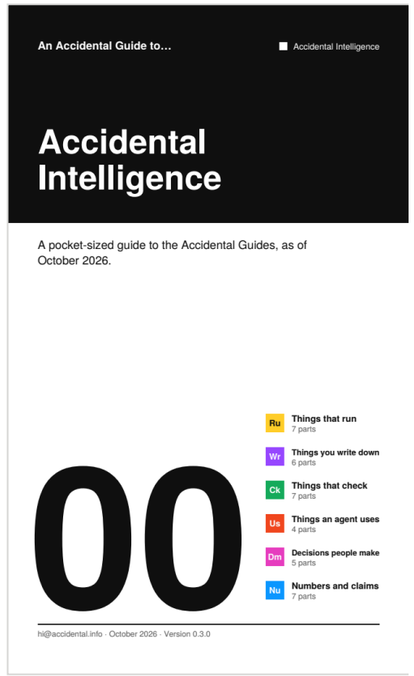
■ 11



▲ 01



◆ 02



■ 00, the catalog

Cost per new guide

None, plus one permanent number

Good

The strongest series identity on a shelf and the cheapest to build. Plain, confident and unmannered. The black band also gives the site and share cards one obvious brand mark.

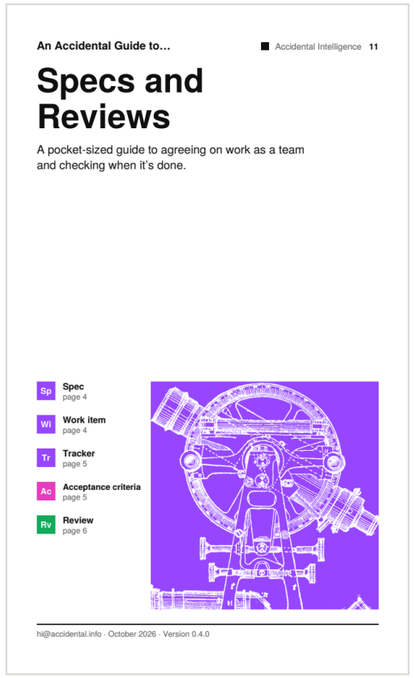
Hard

A number tells the reader nothing: “11” isn’t a reason to pick a guide. Numbers repeat across collections (three 02s on the shelf below). The band is heavy for a pocket guide meant to calm a nervous reader, and C is the furthest from Brian’s wish for illustration. Don’t use the site’s two-letter guide codes instead: Sp, Sk, Mc and He are already part codes.

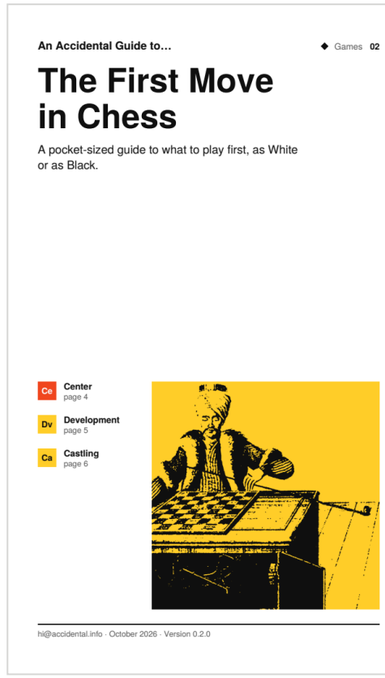
D

Engravings, reduced

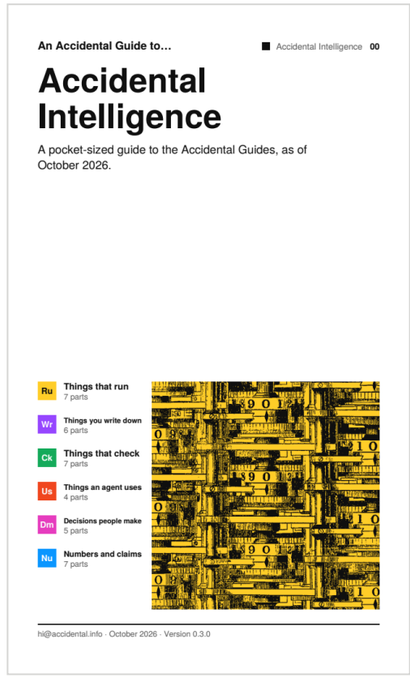
The hybrid: the same engravings, cropped hard into the same two-column square as A, either duotoned on a solid ground of the guide's main family colour (lines knocked out white; ink on yellow, as the tiles do) or in ink on the grey block.



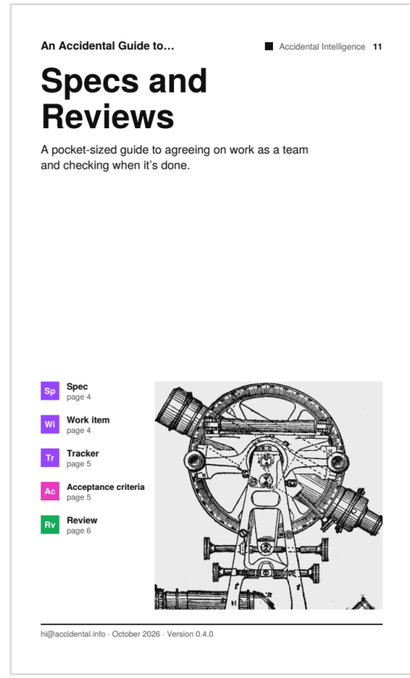
Duotone: works on purple



Duotone: the costume becomes the subject



Duotone: dense plates turn to noise



Ink on grey: D at its most restrained

Cost per new guide

An archive search, a licence check, a cleanup pass, a crop and a credit line

Good

It fixes the placement problem: every picture gets the same field and a hard edge, as Marber and Unigrid did. The purple theodolite and the grey version are handsome, in a museum-catalogue way.

Against

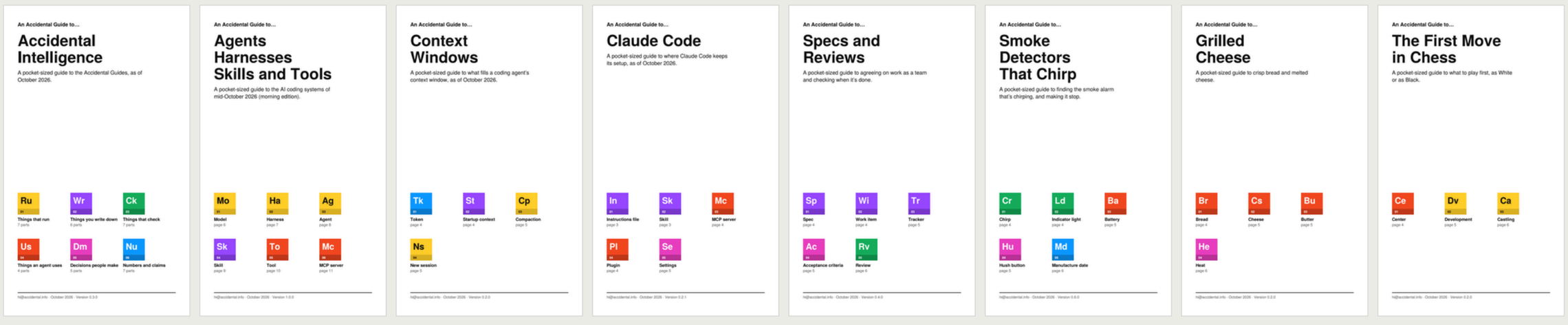
It fixes the grid but not the era, the density or the metaphors. A large field of family colour says "this guide is purple", which breaks the one-meaning rule `colors.md` was written to protect. Four of these eight guides come out yellow, the weakest ground. Hard crops lose the silhouette that made the engravings readable. And duotoned archive art is a current fashion that will date quickly. I'd argue against it.

03 · Shelves

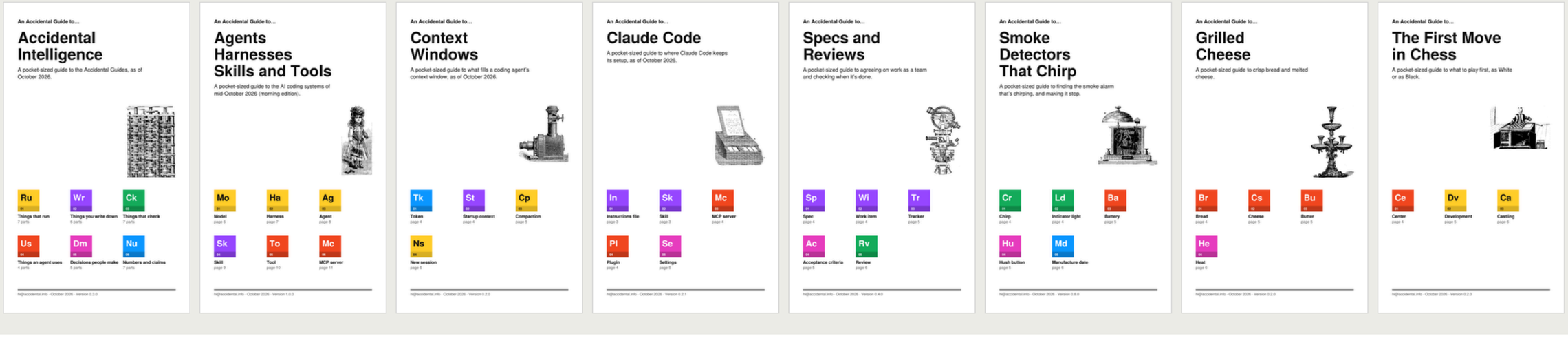
Unity is the point, so judge them in a row

The same eight guides from three collections: the catalog, four AI guides, one house, one table, one games. Each shelf is shown at reading size, then at the size the site lists them.

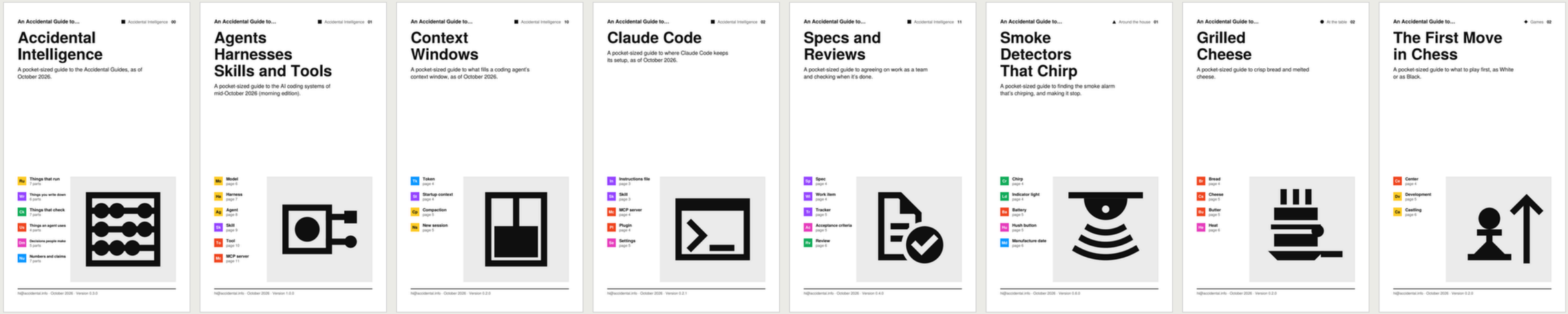
Now One white card, eight times



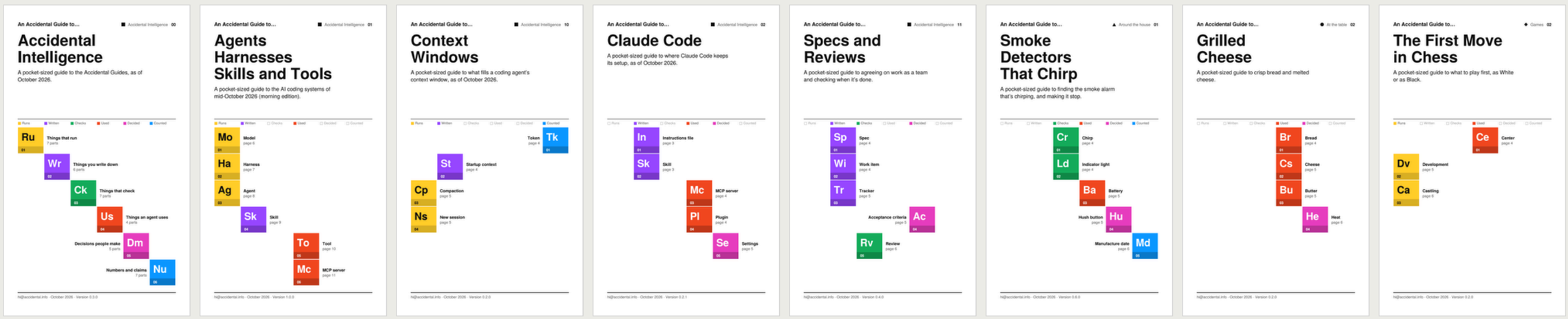
E · Engravings Different, but each picture is its own world



A · Signs An even beat of grey squares; the subject at a glance

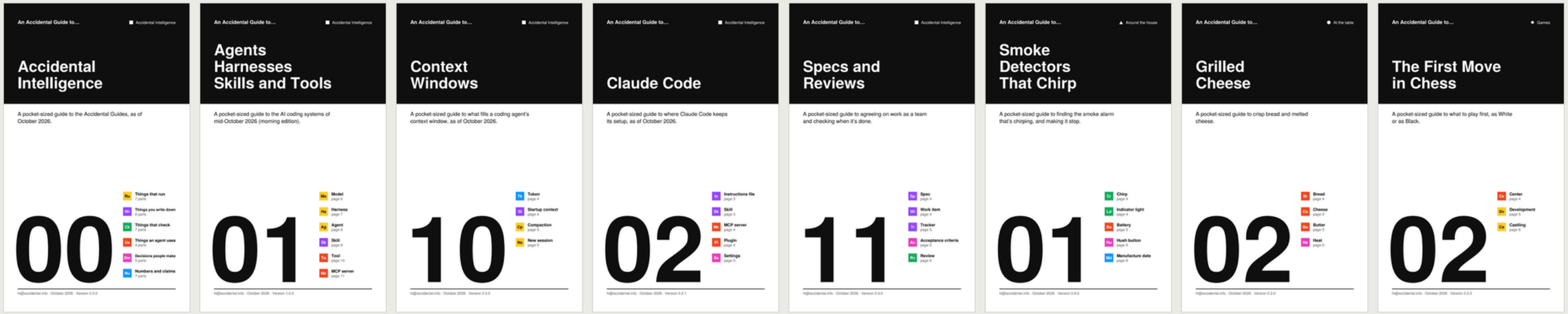


B · The part grid Eight patterns, one system



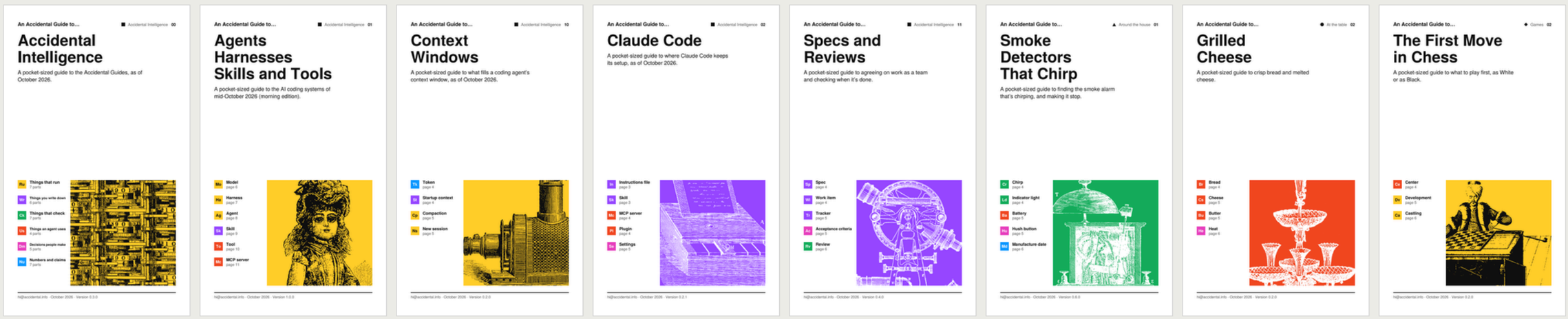
C · Band and number

The loudest series mark



D · Engravings, reduced

A magazine rack



At site size, about 96 px wide

Top to bottom: now, E, A, B, C, D. Dense engravings go to grey. The signs and B's patterns still read, and C's bands read best.



04 · Trade-offs

What each one costs and buys

	E · Engravings	A · Signs	B · Part grid	C · Band and number	D · Reduced
Unity with the system	Weak A second visual language	Strong Grey block, one stroke, no colour	**Strongest** Made of the system’s own tiles	Strong Type only	Fair Grid yes, era no
Tells covers apart at thumbnail	Fair Dense plates blur	Strong	**Strong** Except sibling guides	Strong But only by number	Fair Colour yes, content no
Says what’s inside	Weak Metaphors for groups	Strong The subject	**Strong** The kinds of parts, in order	None	Weak
Colour keeps one meaning	Yes	Yes	**Yes, and teaches it**	Yes	No
Charm and wit	Most	Some, if drawn well	Little; it lives in the words	Little	Some
Cost per new guide	Search, licence, clean	20–60 min of drawing	**Nothing**	Nothing	Search, licence, clean, crop
Builder change	Image + placement	Cover + signs module	Cover only, about 40 lines	Cover only, about 25 lines	Image pipeline
Biggest risk	Reads as O’Reilly pastiche	Abstract AI subjects become stock icons	Feels like a chart; siblings look alike	Austere; numbers mean nothing	Dates quickly

05 · Recommendation

Use B, the part grid

It’s the only direction where the cover art is the guide’s own content, and where the series’ one real visual idea, the same kind of part in the same colour everywhere, does the work. It costs nothing per guide, so it scales to dozens and to new collections by itself. It also fulfils a decision already made in `design-direction.md`: show which families a guide covers on its cover.

Why not A?

A is the close second, and the right choice if Brian wants a picture on every cover. Its rule book is in `scripts/pictograms.py`. But two-thirds of the series is about abstract software, and that’s where pictograms turn into stock icons and where the per-guide drawing time goes. If A is chosen, budget for it: every new guide needs a sign drawn to the rules before it ships.

What it costs in the builders

- **build_guide.py:** in `page_cover()`, replace the three-column tile loop with the grid: six column heads, one tile per entry at (family, row), and a label beside it. About 40 lines, using `avatar()`, `FAMILY_TOKEN` and `PART_FAMILY`, which already exist. Add the series line (collection mark, name, number), which needs the collection id and number in each guide’s content or read from `collections.json`. About half a day in `packages/template`, plus a check that six rows of 46 pt clear a three-line title and two-line subtitle (they do, with 40 pt to spare).
- **Rolling out:** every guide carries its own copy of the builder, so the change goes to 24 `build_guide.py` files, with new `expected.sha256` files and a patch version each. Four older builders (Agents, Claude Code, Claude Desktop, Software Factories) need `PART_FAMILY` first, the family migration `colors.md` already describes.
- **build_docx.py:** the Word cover becomes a 6 × 6 table with shaded cells. Simple, but `cover_gap()` needs redoing.
- **The site** needs no change for covers: `guide_pages.py` makes `cover.png` and `card.png` from each PDF’s first page. Optionally, use the 6 × 6 pattern as a small mark in lists.
- **Mockup code:** `scripts/covers.py`, `cover_grid()`, is a working ReportLab prototype on the guides’ constants. Port it, don’t reinvent it.

Where the engravings live

Not on the covers and not in the guides. Give them one place where era and wit are the point: the site's about page, as a short "From the archive" strip of the machines that came before (Babbage's engine, the Turk, the loom), each with its credit line. The joke survives there without fighting the system. The 404 page could take one too. Everything is already in `engravings/clean` with full records in `shortlist.json`. If even that feels like decoration, leave them out entirely; the guides lose nothing.

What Brian needs to decide

01 **B, or A.** The part grid as recommended, or signs if a picture on every cover matters more than zero cost per guide.

02 **Collection marks in black, not colour.** Swap the site's collection colours for ■ ▲ ● ◆, so yellow stops meaning both "things that run" and "the house".

03 **A guide number on the cover?** If yes, numbers are permanent and never reused. B and A work without them.

04 **The six column words:** Runs, Written, Checks, Used, Decided, Counted. Short enough for 46 pt, and they work for bread as well as for MCP.

05 **The engravings:** about page and 404, or nowhere.

How this was made

All covers were drawn by `scripts/covers.py` with ReportLab on the guides' page size, margins, TeX Gyre Heros and two-tone tile, then rendered at 2× with pypdfium2. Titles, subtitles, parts, families and page numbers come from the repository by `scripts/data.py` (read only). Family colours follow `packages/editorial/registry.md`. The signs were drawn for this study on a 12-unit grid in `scripts/pictograms.py`; nothing was traced. The "Now" covers are redrawn the same way so every comparison uses one renderer.

Engravings are public domain; sources and licences are in `~/Claude/accidental-guides/engravings/shortlist.json` (Figuier, *Les Merveilles de la science*; Scammell's *Cyclopedia*, 1897; *Popular Science Monthly*, 1891; *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, 1911; *Harper's*, 1864). TeX Gyre Heros is under the GUST Font License, included in `fonts/`.

Rebuild: `~/github/stuffbucket/accidentalguide/.venv/bin/python scripts/data.py && …/python scripts/covers.py && …/python scripts/covers.py all-b && …/python scripts/specimen.py`